calls a *cassette*. When the test is run again, VCR intercepts the request. Rather than actually making the request as a network call, VCR converts the cassette back into a response object and returns that response object. By default, if you then make an HTTP request that the VCR cassette doesn't know about, the test will fail.

VCR has many great features. Because the data that VCR stores is based on a real request, it's real data, meaning your tests are not running on some slapdash mock object you put together. This makes the tests have greater fidelity to the runtime environment, which makes them more trustworthy. Often, VCR is just a "set it and forget it" tool. Sometimes when you change a test, you need to manually force VCR to re-record data, though. You can even set VCR to automatically regenerate the cassette on an arbitrary time frame to protect against changes in the API. One potential downside is that having easy and fast stubbed data can lead to writing integration tests against the API when unit tests might be more appropriate.

Prescription 37	Use the VCR gem to allow your integration tests to run against server response data.

VCR is very configurable, allowing you to specify URLs or patterns that should be allowed to pass through without VCR caring (a common one being `localhost`). You can also do some pattern matching as to what constitutes the same URL for VCR purposes—many APIs have some kind of timestamp parameter that you'd want VCR to overlook for the purposes of returning stubbed output.

VCR and RSpec

You can use RSpec metadata to specify that any RSpec `it` or `describe` block uses a VCR cassette. The configuration goes into another RSpec support file:

external/01/spec/support/vcr.rb

```
VCR.configure do |c|
  c.cassette_library_dir = "spec/cassettes"
  c.hook_into :webmock
  c.configure_rspec_metadata!
  c.ignore_localhost = true
end
```

Here, four options are specified: first, the directory where VCR is going to place its cassette files (which can be anything you want, but something like `spec/cassettes` is customary).

The second option involves the HTTP stub library. VCR handles the creation and use of the cassette files, but it subcontracts the actual stubbing of HTTP